DURGA KATHA

THE COMIC BOOK | VOLUME 1 | REVISED EDITION

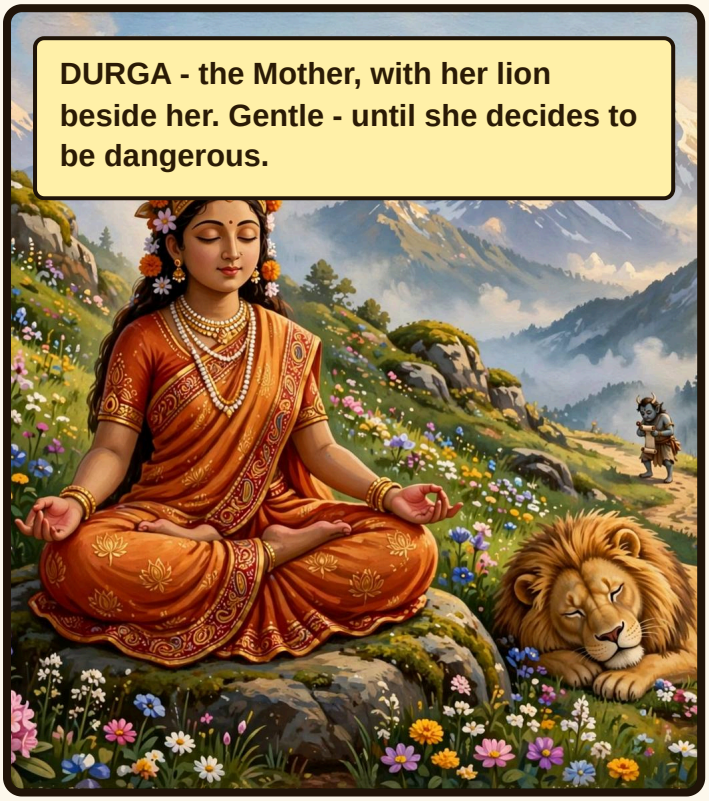


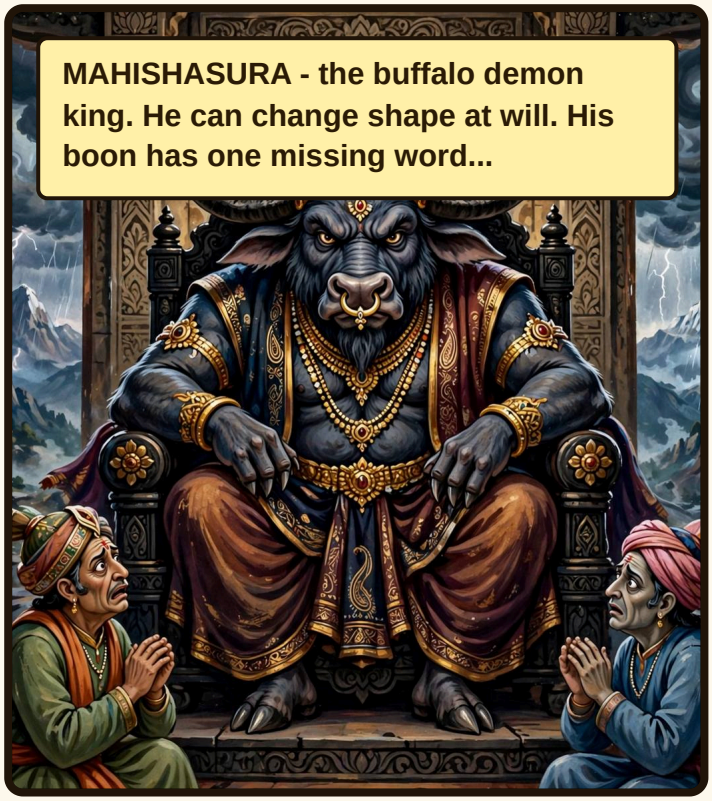
Mahishasura, the Buffalo Demon - Raktabeej, Who Multiplied - Shumbha and Nishumbha, the Last Two Brothers

Three battles of the Mother Goddess, from the Devi Mahatmyam - told panel by panel, to be read aloud together.

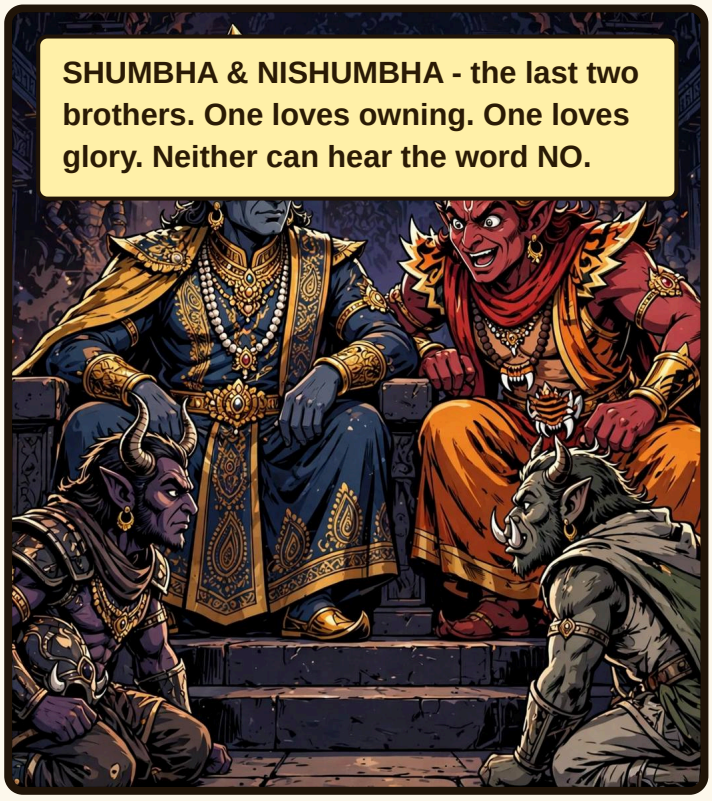
MEET THE HEROES - AND THE DEMONS

Listen first: Long before these tales were written, they were told by lamplight. Whenever darkness grew too proud, the Mother came. Her name is **Durga** - the fort no enemy can break. She is Shakti, the energy inside everything. Watch for the pattern: a demon wins a clever boon... the gods find their power is not enough... and then all their light joins into **one flame - a woman.** The demons always laugh first. Remember that.









THE FACES YOU WILL MEET - LOOK FOR THEM IN EVERY PANEL

THE DESIGN OF THIS BOOK: Kali (left, deep blue-black, white garland, dark sari) - Durga (centre, red-and-gold sari and armour, tall crown with one red jewel) - Kaushiki (right, white-and-gold) - Mahishasura the buffalo (front) - and the lion, courage with a mane. In this edition they keep the same faces, crowns and colours in every panel, so young listeners can spot them at a glance.



How to read this comic aloud

Yellow boxes are the STORYTELLER - that is you, telling what happened. Read them in your normal, warm voice.

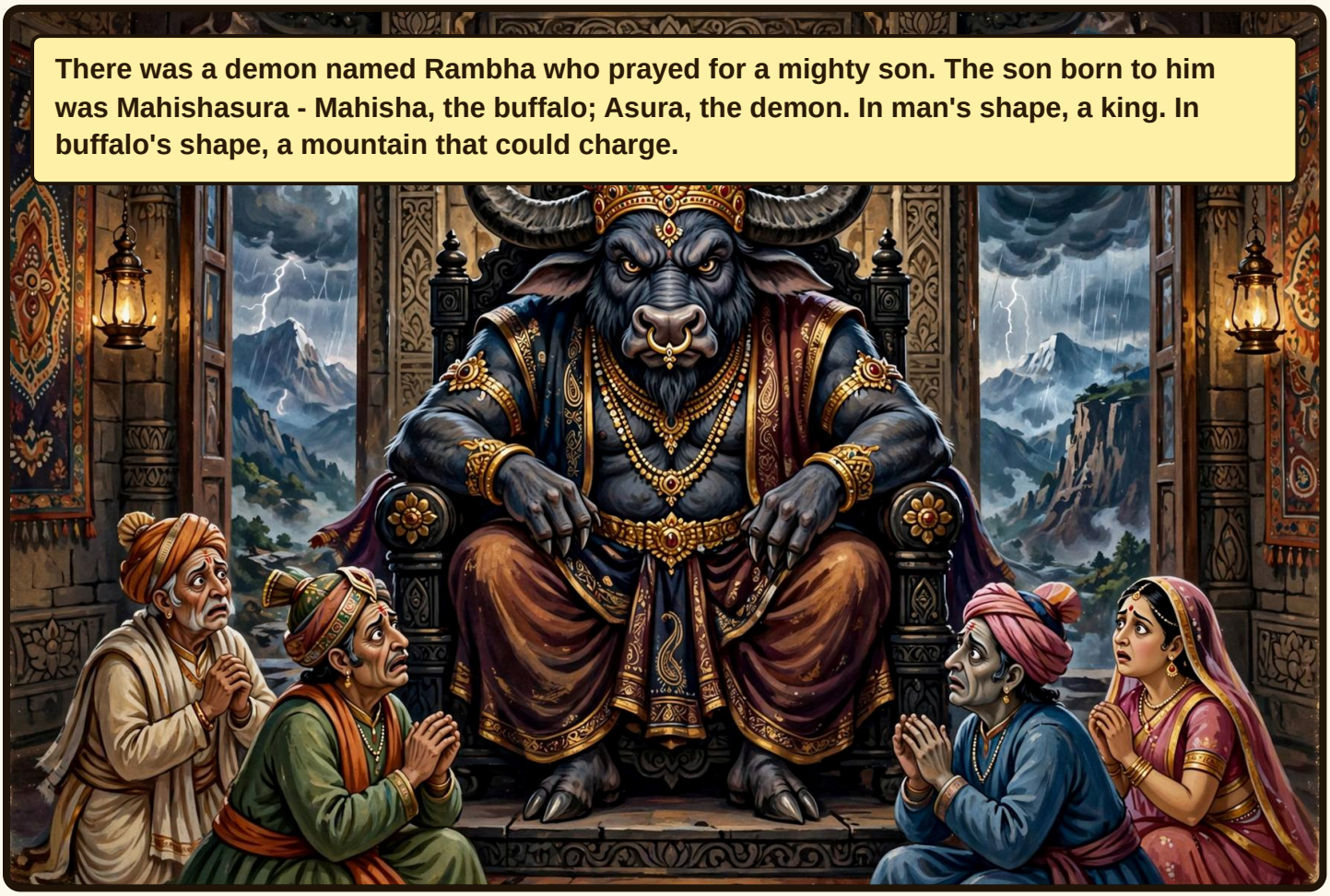
White round bubbles are the CHARACTERS speaking. That is your cue to change voice: low and proud for demons, calm and clear for the Goddess.

Big jagged words - DHADAM! HUM! - are sounds. Say them loudly. That part is not optional.



STORY ONE
MAHISHASURA, THE BUFFALO DEMON

How a boon with one missing word brought down a king of demons.


There was a demon named Rambha who prayed for a mighty son. The son born to him was Mahishasura - Mahisha, the buffalo; Asura, the demon. In man's shape, a king. In buffalo's shape, a mountain that could charge.


Mahishasura wanted not a kingdom - THE kingdom. Earth below, heaven above. So first, he bought safety with prayer. For years he stood in penance, through heat and frost, calling on Brahma, the Creator...
BRAHMA: Ask, and it shall be given.

THE BOON WITH ONE MISSING WORD



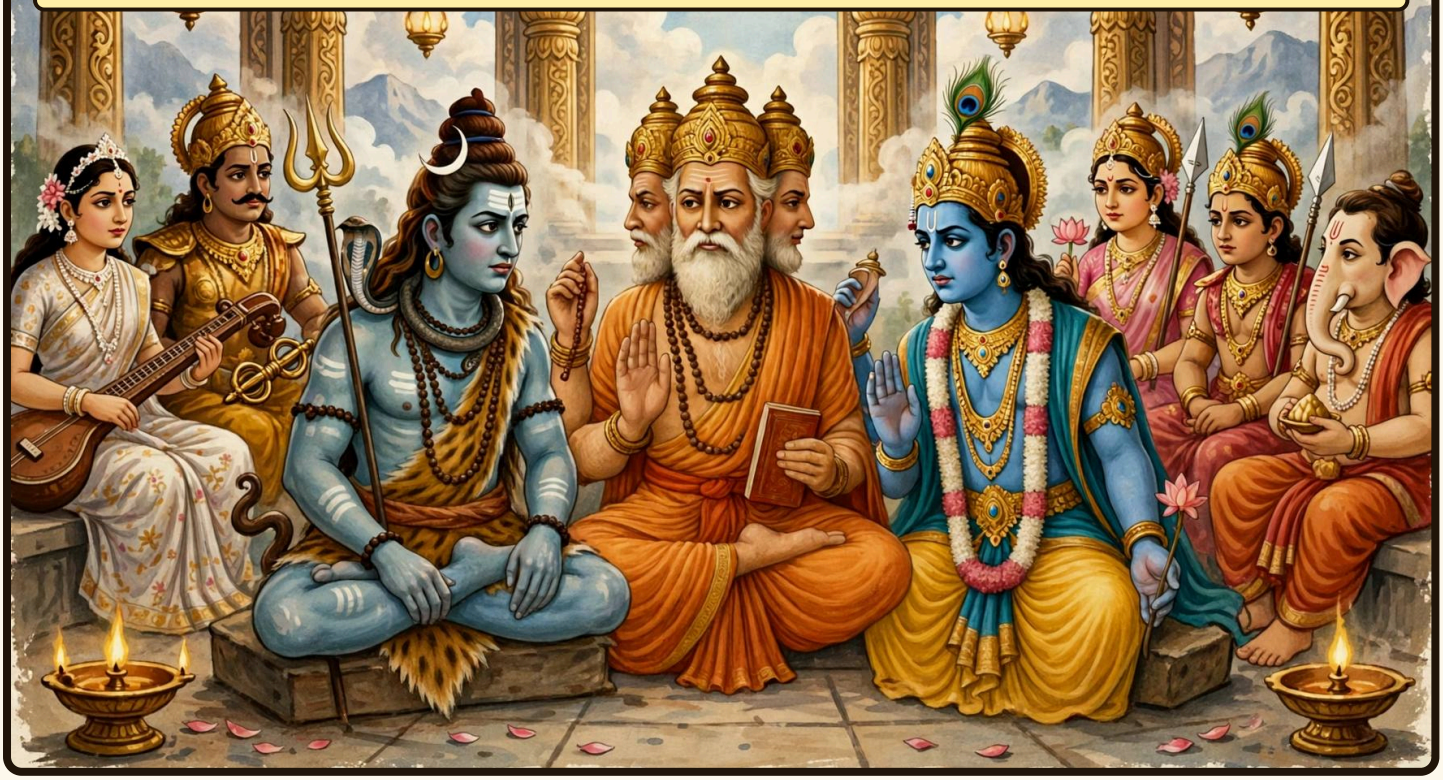
He chose those words because he believed them **safe**. A woman, in his proud mind, was no warrior at all.

Brahma, who sees further than the proud, simply said: *So be it.*

With the boon warming his chest, Mahishasura marched. His armies poured across the earth like a flood. Then he turned his face UPWARD - and defeated Indra, king of the gods, in open war.



For a hundred years the gods were refugees in their own heaven. A hundred years of sages whispering prayers instead of singing them. At last they went together to Brahma... and Brahma led them to Vishnu and Shiva.

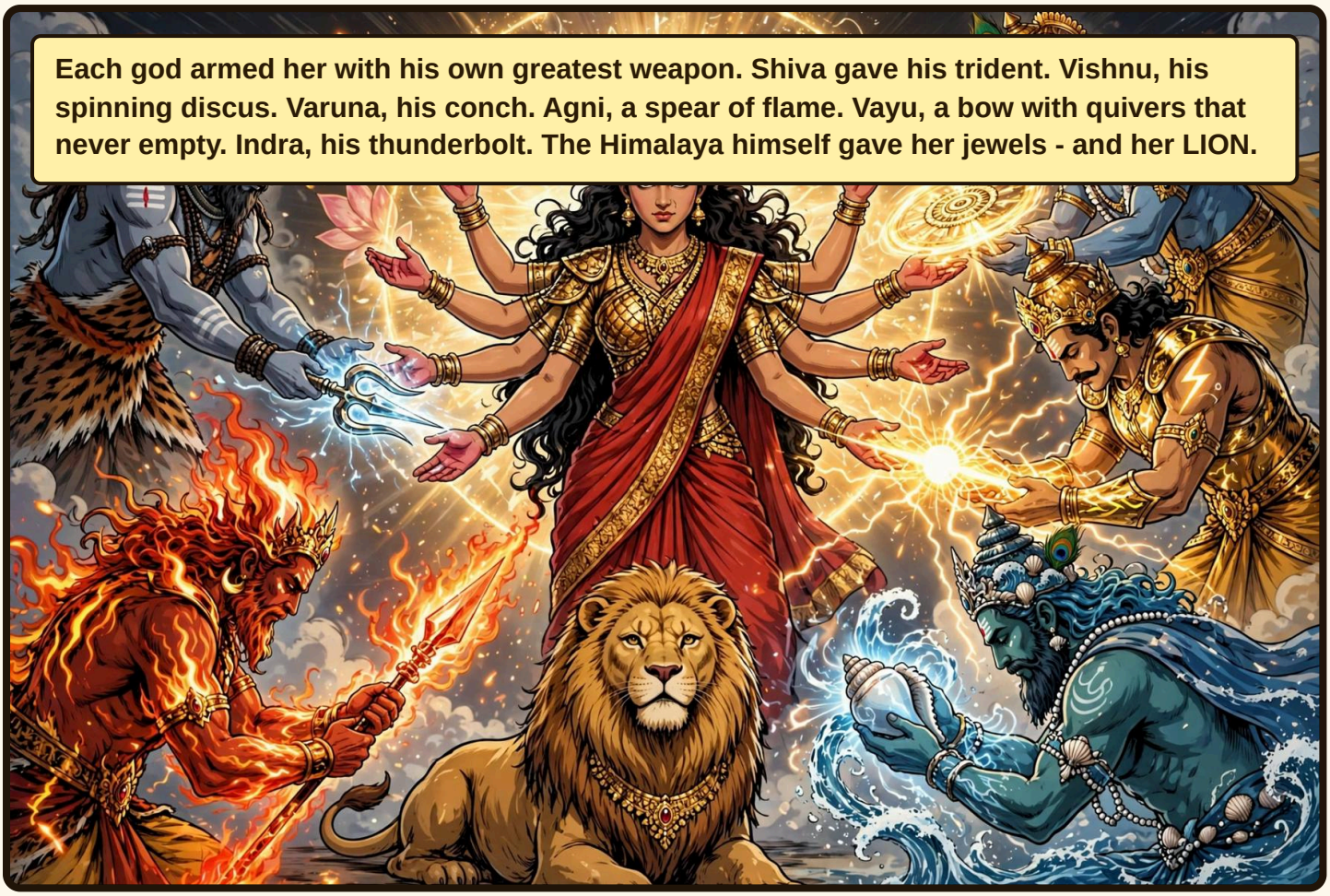


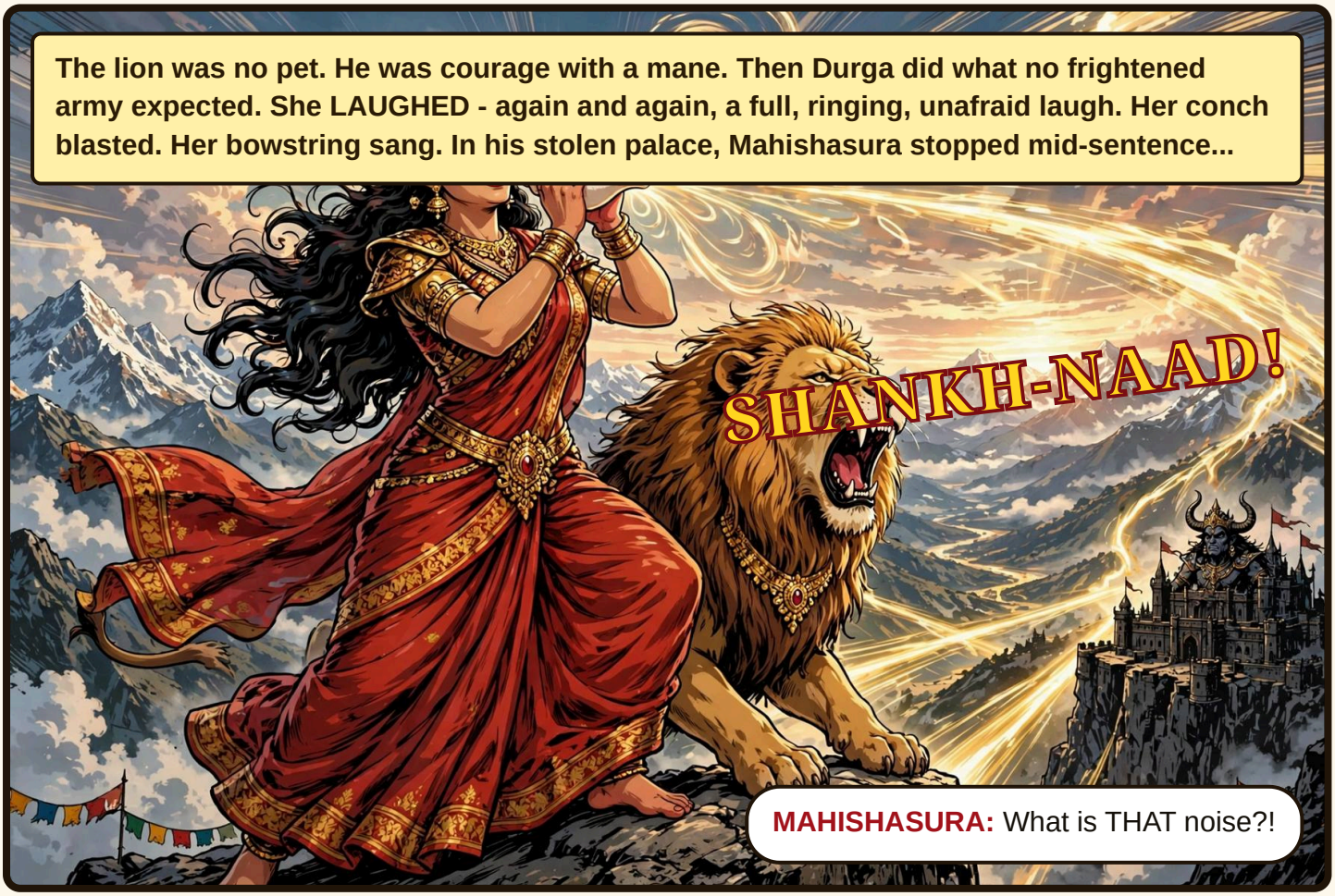
As the gods poured out their shame, righteous rage lit the faces of Vishnu and Shiva. Light streamed from every god - and the lights did not scatter. They flowed together into one column of flame... and the flame took the shape of a WOMAN. Her face from Shiva's light. Her arms from Vishnu's radiance. She was all of them, gathered - and more: the Shakti who had lent them their power, come to collect it in person.



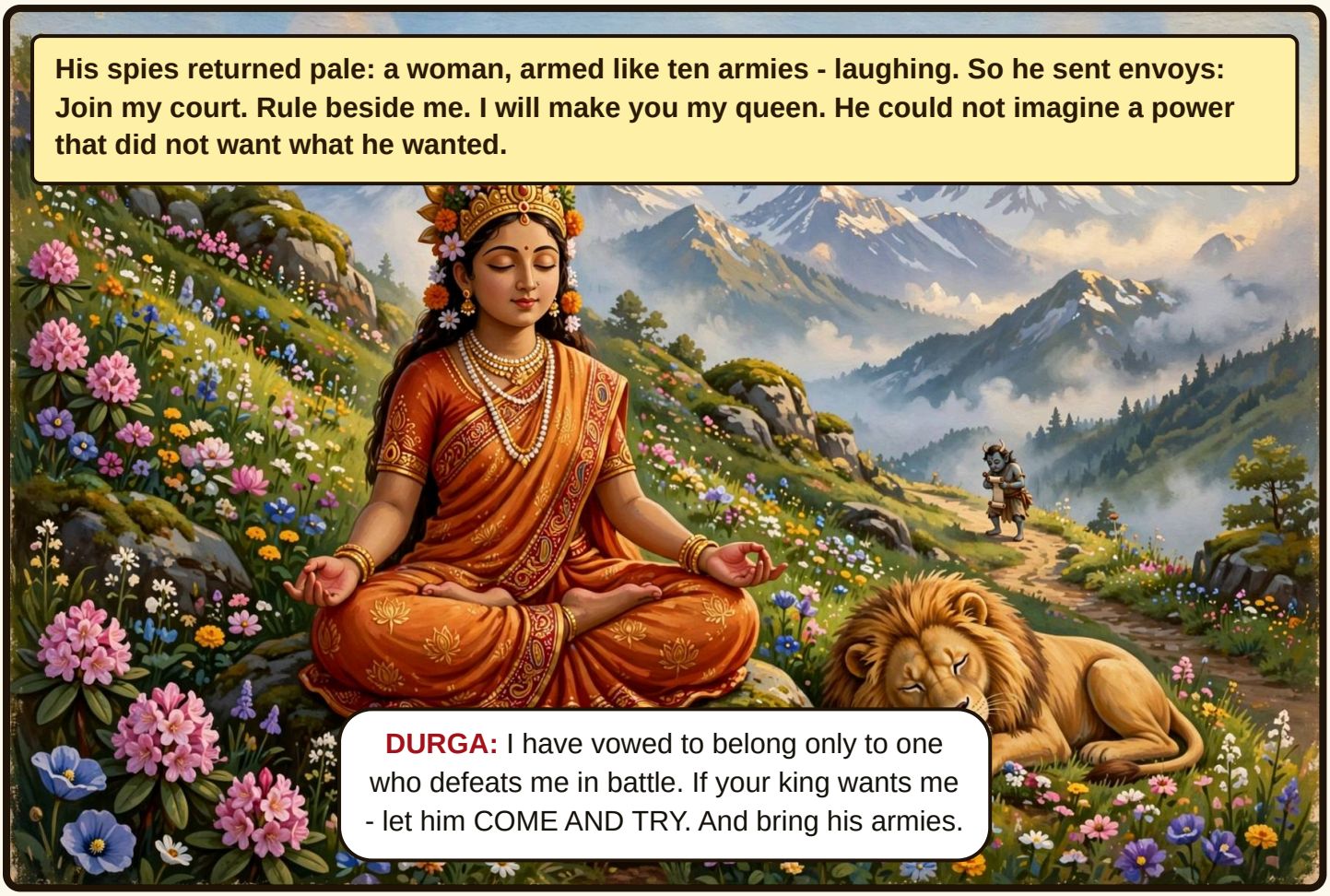
AND SO... DURGA WAS BORN

The gods, a moment ago refugees, bowed like children who have just seen their mother walk into the room.


Each god armed her with his own greatest weapon. Shiva gave his trident. Vishnu, his spinning discus. Varuna, his conch. Agni, a spear of flame. Vayu, a bow with quivers that never empty. Indra, his thunderbolt. The Himalaya himself gave her jewels - and her LION.


The lion was no pet. He was courage with a mane. Then Durga did what no frightened army expected. She LAUGHED - again and again, a full, ringing, unafraid laugh. Her conch blasted. Her bowstring sang. In his stolen palace, Mahishasura stopped mid-sentence...
SHANKH-NAAD!
MAHISHASURA: What is THAT noise?!

"COME AND TRY"


His spies returned pale: a woman, armed like ten armies - laughing. So he sent envoys: Join my court. Rule beside me. I will make you my queen. He could not imagine a power that did not want what he wanted.
DURGA: I have vowed to belong only to one who defeats me in battle. If your king wants me - let him COME AND TRY. And bring his armies.


His generals went first - Chikshura, Chamara, Udagra - armies beyond counting: elephants, chariots, horsemen. Durga's arrows met them like rain meeting a river, and her lion moved like a forest fire through dry grass. One by one, the great generals fell.
GARRR!

At last the palace gates opened - and out came the buffalo himself, vast and black, shaking the earth, tossing chariots with his horns. Durga bound him with her noose - he was a LION, slipping free! She raised her sword - he was a SWORDSMAN, laughing! Arrows rained - he was an ELEPHANT, trumpeting!



Nothing could kill him, because nothing could KEEP him. But Durga was not confused, and she was not hurried. She watched him the way a mother cat watches a mouse that believes the room is his. She was waiting for the one moment every shape-shifter must pass through: the moment BETWEEN shapes, when he is truly himself.



THE MOMENT BETWEEN SHAPES

It came as the buffalo thundered in for the final charge. Durga sprang from her lion, light as a dancer, and landed on his back - one foot pressing his great neck into the dust. Beneath her the shape began to slip... and out, half-formed, sword in hand, came the demon in man's shape. THAT was the moment. Her trident took him, swift and clean, the way lightning takes a tree.



Then - flowers fell from the sky like slow, glad rain, and the heavenly drums, silenced for a hundred years, sounded again.



What this story leaves with us: Mahishasura was defeated by the one possibility his pride could not imagine. On earth, the tenth day after Navratri is still kept as **Vijayadashami - the Day of Victory.**

Mahishasura: the ego that keeps changing shape

Notice how Durga actually wins. She does not out-argue the buffalo, and she does not chase every shape he takes - lion, swordsman, elephant. She waits for the moment *between* shapes, the one instant he is truly himself.

That is why this demon has lasted three thousand years as a story. Stubborn ego behaves exactly like him. Corner it as laziness, and it returns as pride. Defeat it as pride, and it comes back as hurt, or habit, or a very reasonable excuse. Anyone who has tried to change one deep habit knows the whole shape-shifting duel by heart.

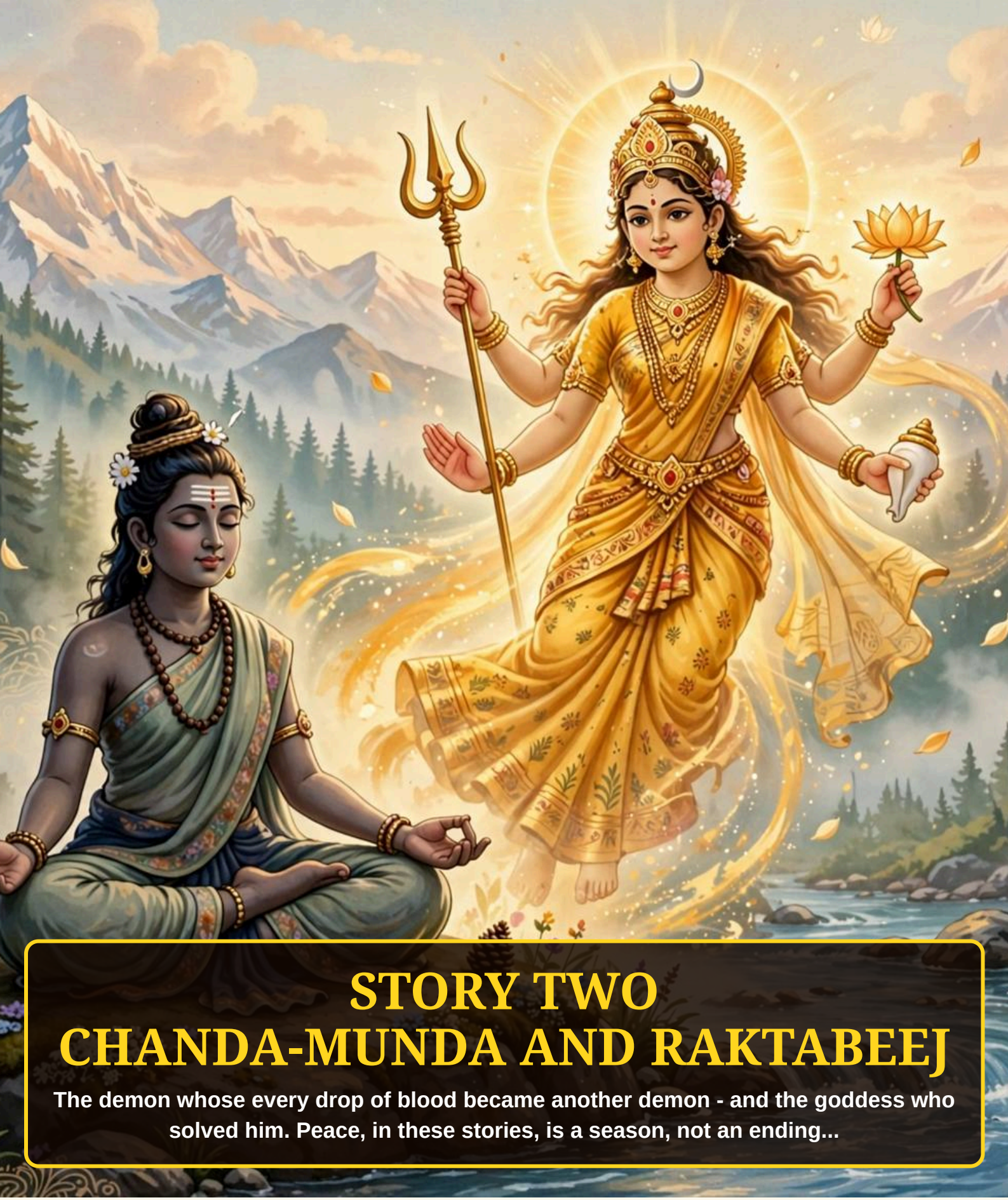
The story's advice is quiet and practical: do not exhaust yourself fighting every costume. Watch patiently. Name the thing itself, in the moment it cannot hide - and meet it there, once, cleanly.

And remember where his one weakness came from: not a flaw in his strength, but a limit in his imagination. He could not picture a woman as a warrior. What we decide is too small to matter has a way of becoming the door.

Source: Devi Mahatmyam (Durga Saptashati), Madhyama Charita - Chapters 2, 3 and 4 of 13: the boon and fall of heaven, Durga's battle, and the slaying of Mahishasura.

PAUSE AND TALK

Is there a habit or a mood in your own life that keeps changing shape - beaten in one form, back by Friday in another? What would its 'moment between shapes' look like?

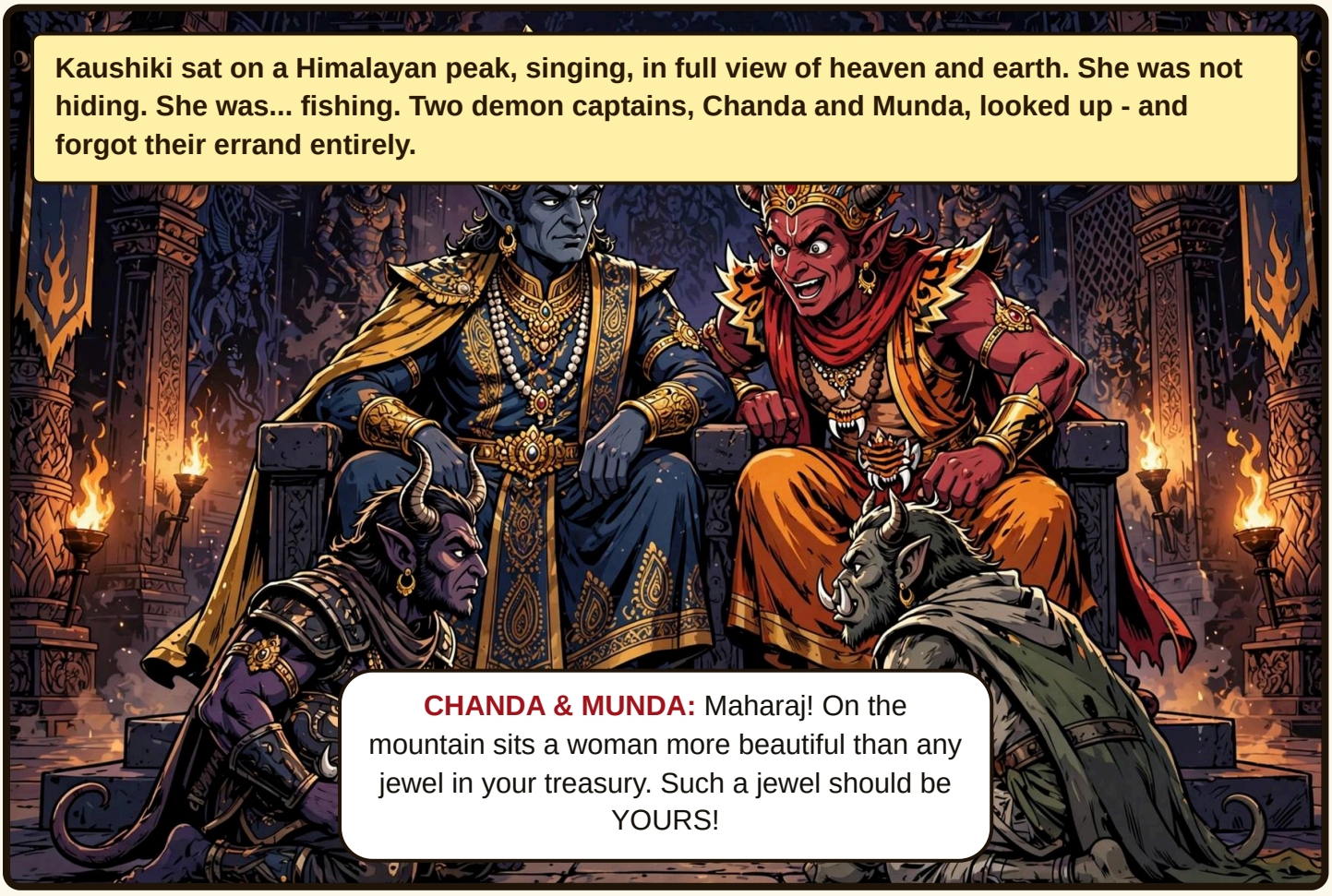


STORY TWO
CHANDA-MUNDA AND RAKTABEEJ

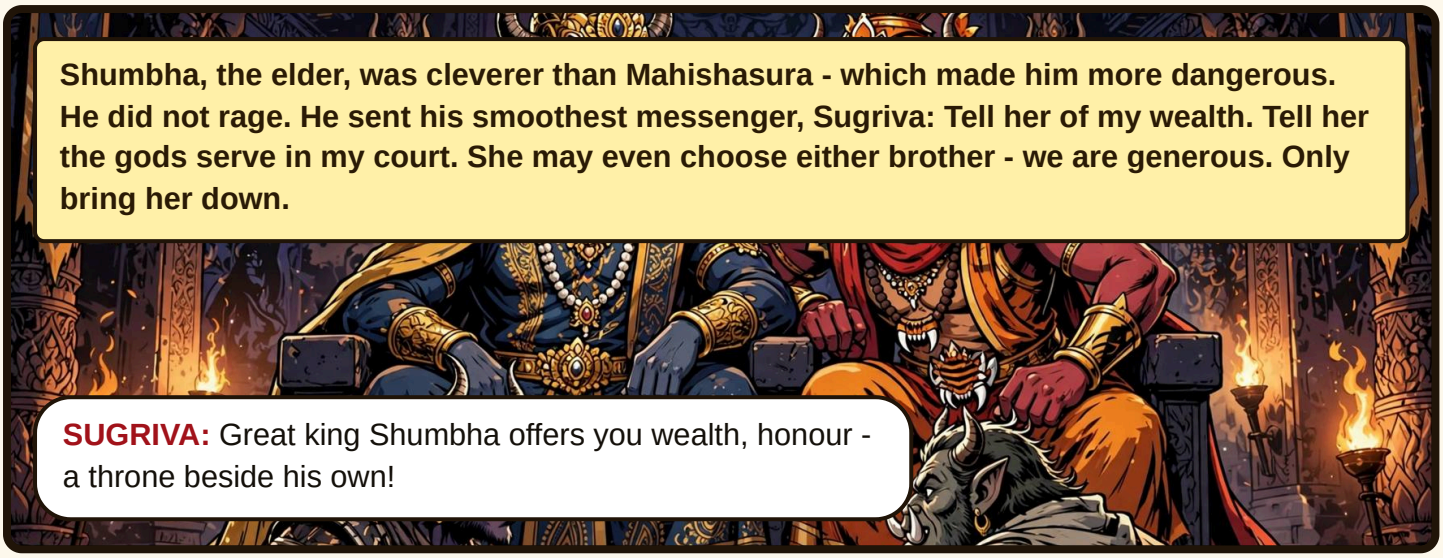
The demon whose every drop of blood became another demon - and the goddess who solved him. Peace, in these stories, is a season, not an ending...

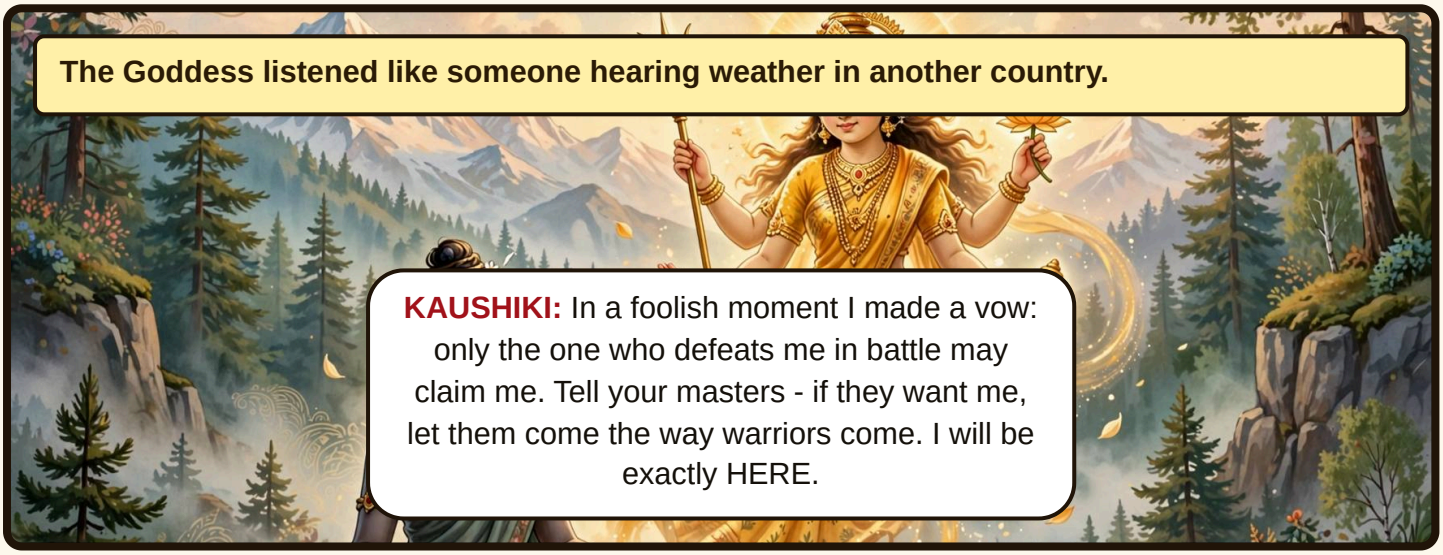
PREVIOUSLY... A buffalo demon who could be killed only by a woman took heaven itself - so all the gods joined their light into one flame, and Durga was born. She laughed, she fought his changing shapes, and she struck in the moment between them. Heaven is free. But peace, in these stories, is a season - not an ending...

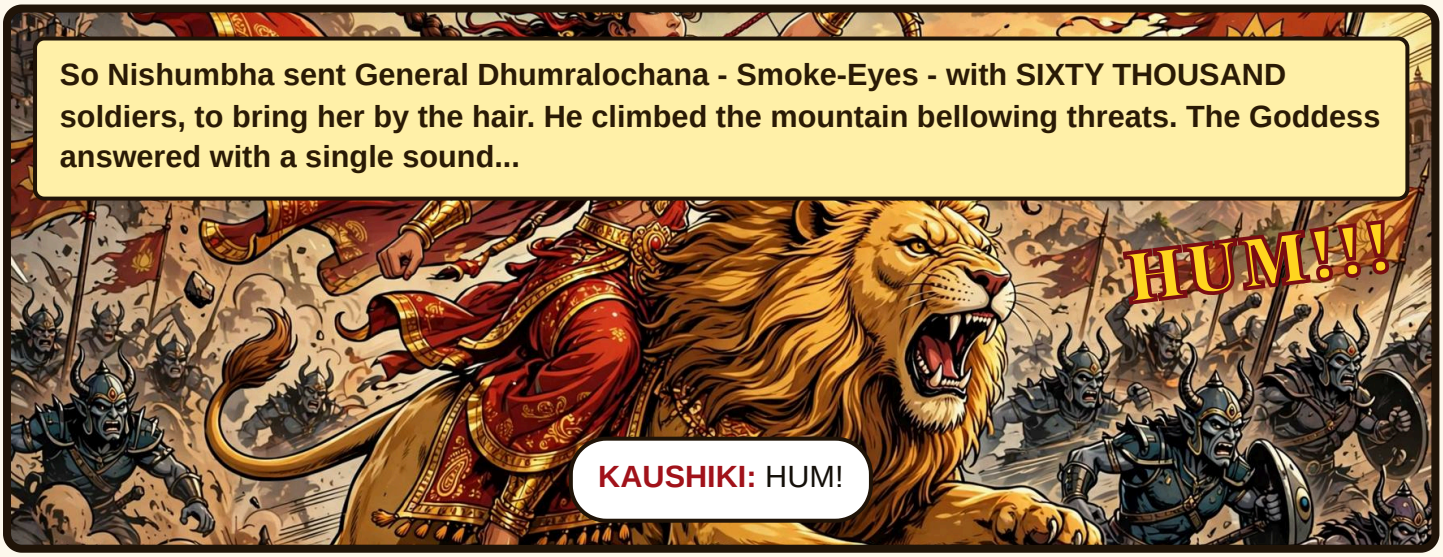

Generations later, two new demon brothers rose: Shumbha and Nishumbha. But first, the Goddess, as Parvati, went to bathe in the Ganga - and from her own body stepped forth a second, radiant form: KAUSHIKI, fair and luminous. The calm mother stays calm; the warrior walks out shining.


Kaushiki sat on a Himalayan peak, singing, in full view of heaven and earth. She was not hiding. She was... fishing. Two demon captains, Chanda and Munda, looked up - and forgot their errand entirely.
CHANDA & MUNDA: Maharaj! On the mountain sits a woman more beautiful than any jewel in your treasury. Such a jewel should be YOURS!

"PERSUADE HER"





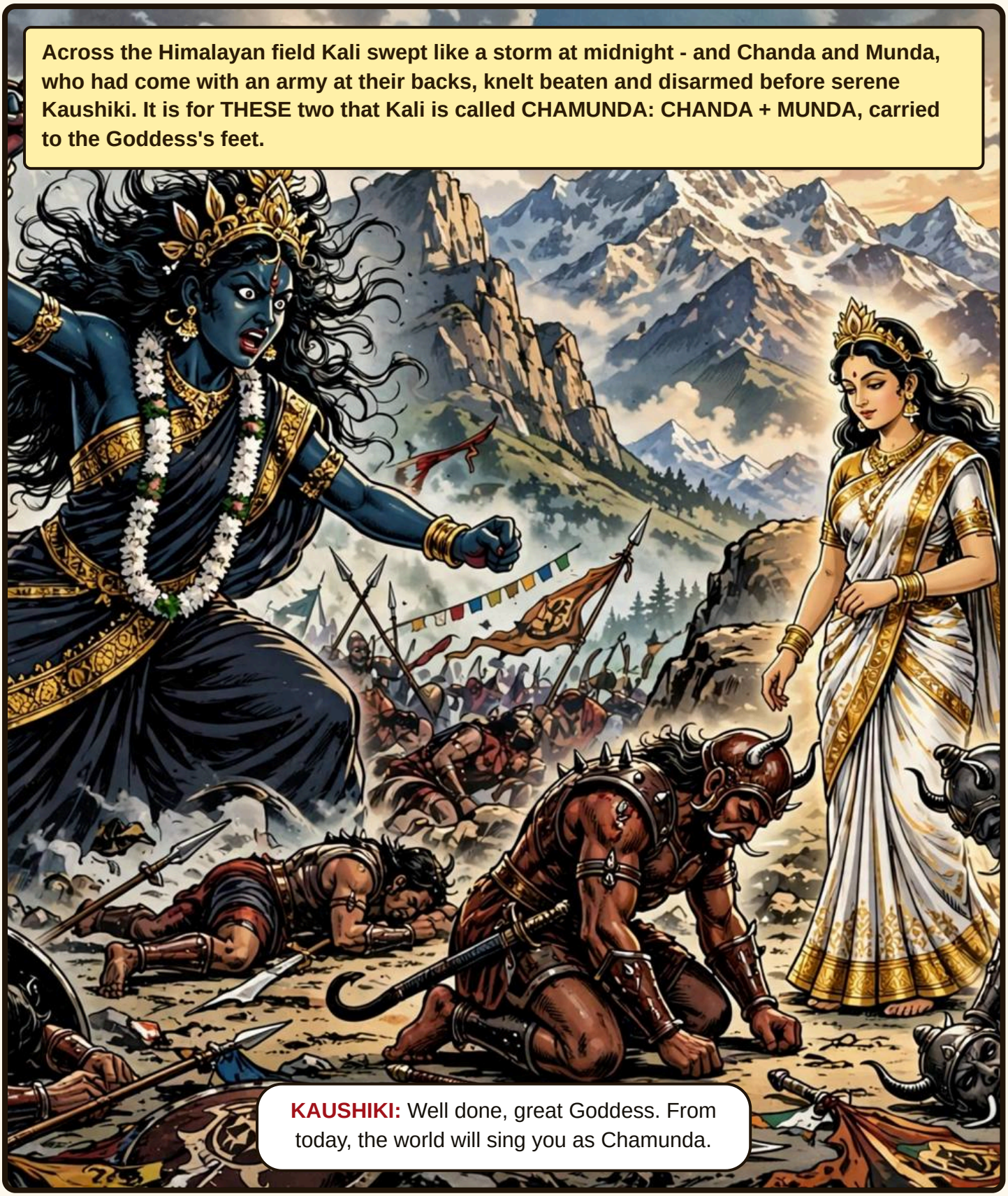


The sound itself was the weapon. Smoke-Eyes was ash before he hit the ground. Her lion did the rest. Sixty thousand had climbed up singing of glory. That evening, the mountain was very quiet - and the Goddess had not risen from her seat.

Now Shumbha sent Chanda and Munda themselves, with the full demon host - shields like a black sea. The Goddess rose, took up her great bow... and then she FROWNED. Out of that frown - dark as a storm at midnight, garlanded, with a skull-cup in her hand - stepped KALI. Not a servant. Not a soldier. The Goddess's own anger, given a face. The demons named her as they ran: CHAMUNDA - for within the hour she had swept through their army and laid Chanda and Munda's defeat at Kaushiki's feet.



THE GODDESS WHO CAME OUT OF A FROWN



Look at the two goddesses together in this panel, listener: Kali, all storm - and Kaushiki, all calm - working as one. The story does not ask us to choose between them. Sometimes love has to be the storm. Sometimes it has to be the stillness the storm reports to.

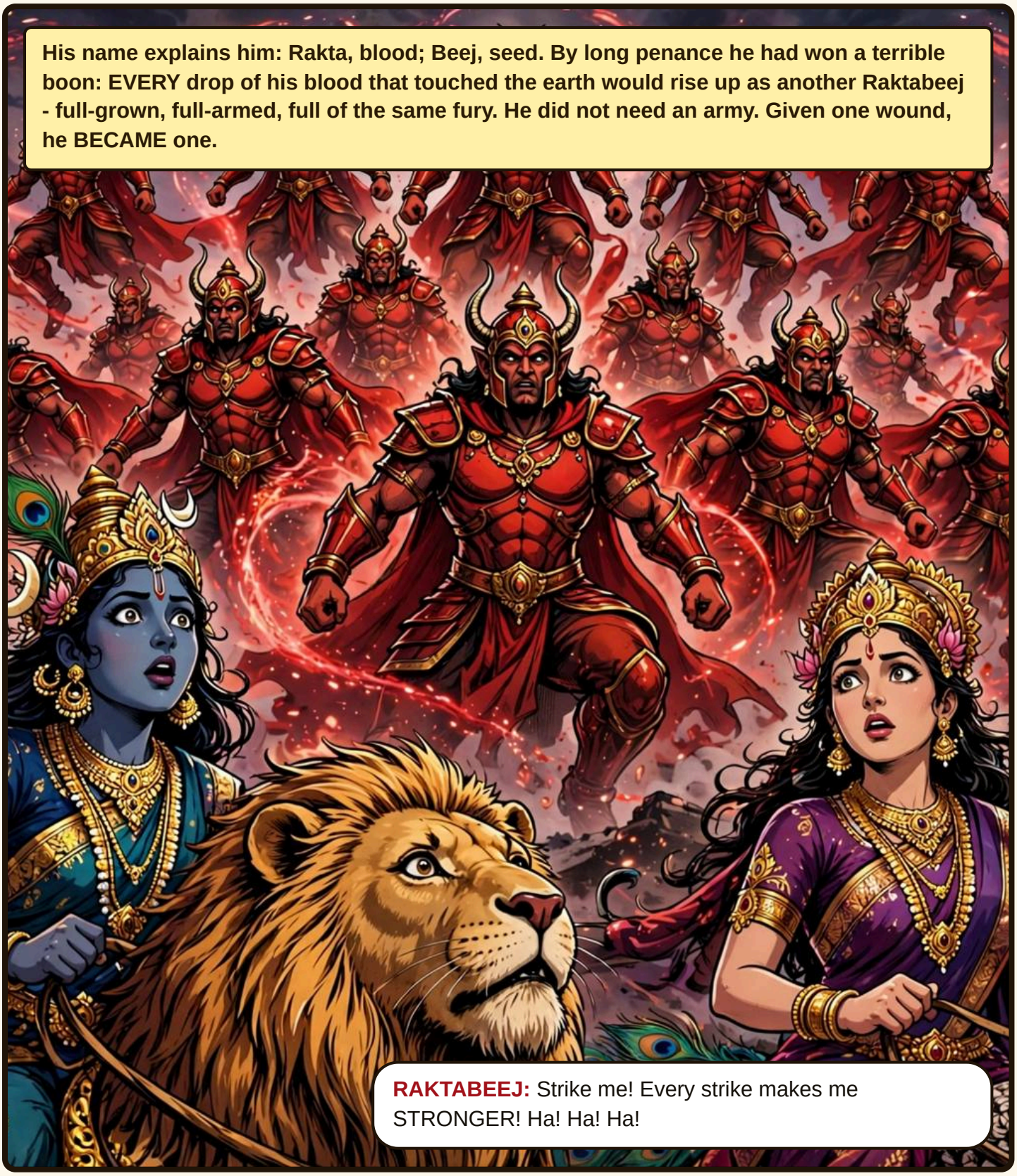
THE DIVINE MOTHERS ARRIVE

From the watching gods, help now came in a form worthy of the moment: the MATRIKAS, the Divine Mothers - the female energies of the great gods themselves. Brahmi from Brahma. Maheshwari from Shiva. Kaumari. Vaishnavi. Varahi. Indrani. Each on her own mount, each with her god's weapons - seven mothers descending in a line of light. The battlefield now held a FAMILY.



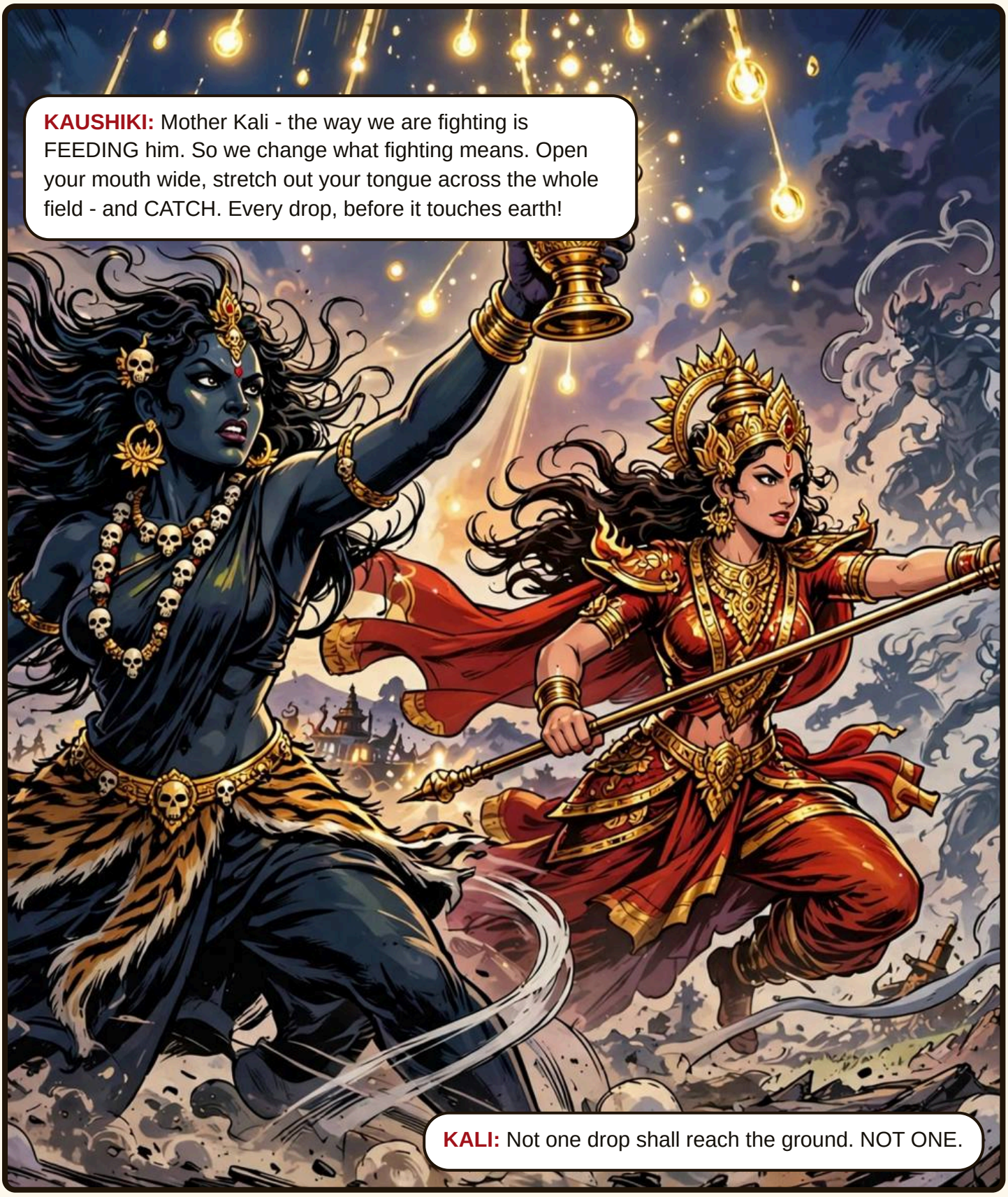
But Shumbha's answer was to unleash the one weapon he had been saving - the demon nobody could kill twice, because he never stayed killed once...





Think about what that meant. Strike him with the discus: a hundred drops, a hundred demons. One perfect sword-cut: a battalion. The Matrikas fought magnificently - and the field filled faster than they emptied it. The goddesses were not losing to a stronger enemy. **They were losing to their own success, one perfect strike at a time.**

"WE WILL CHANGE WHAT FIGHTING MEANS"



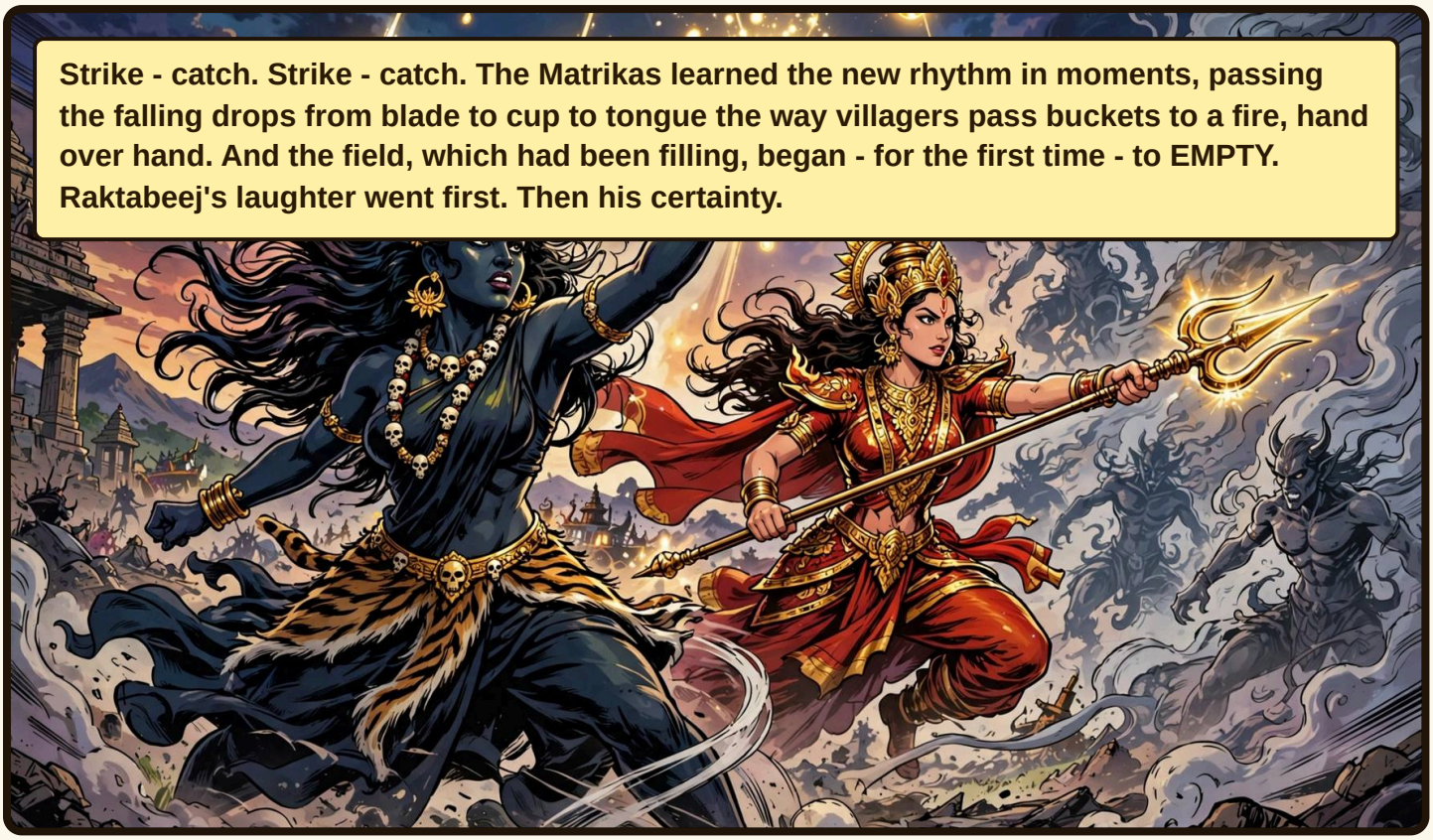
Raktabeej's boon had one condition hidden inside it, as all boons do: **the blood must reach the ground.** Kaushiki had not found a stronger weapon. She had found the condition - and stepped around it, the way a river steps around a stone.

THE CLIMAX - STRIKE, CATCH. STRIKE, CATCH. Kali stretched herself across the whole battlefield, tongue out, cup ready, catching every single drop in mid-air - while above her the Matrikas struck, and struck again, and no new demon rose. Raktabeej watched his endless army simply... stop arriving. A boon is only as strong as its one condition - and his condition never reached the ground.

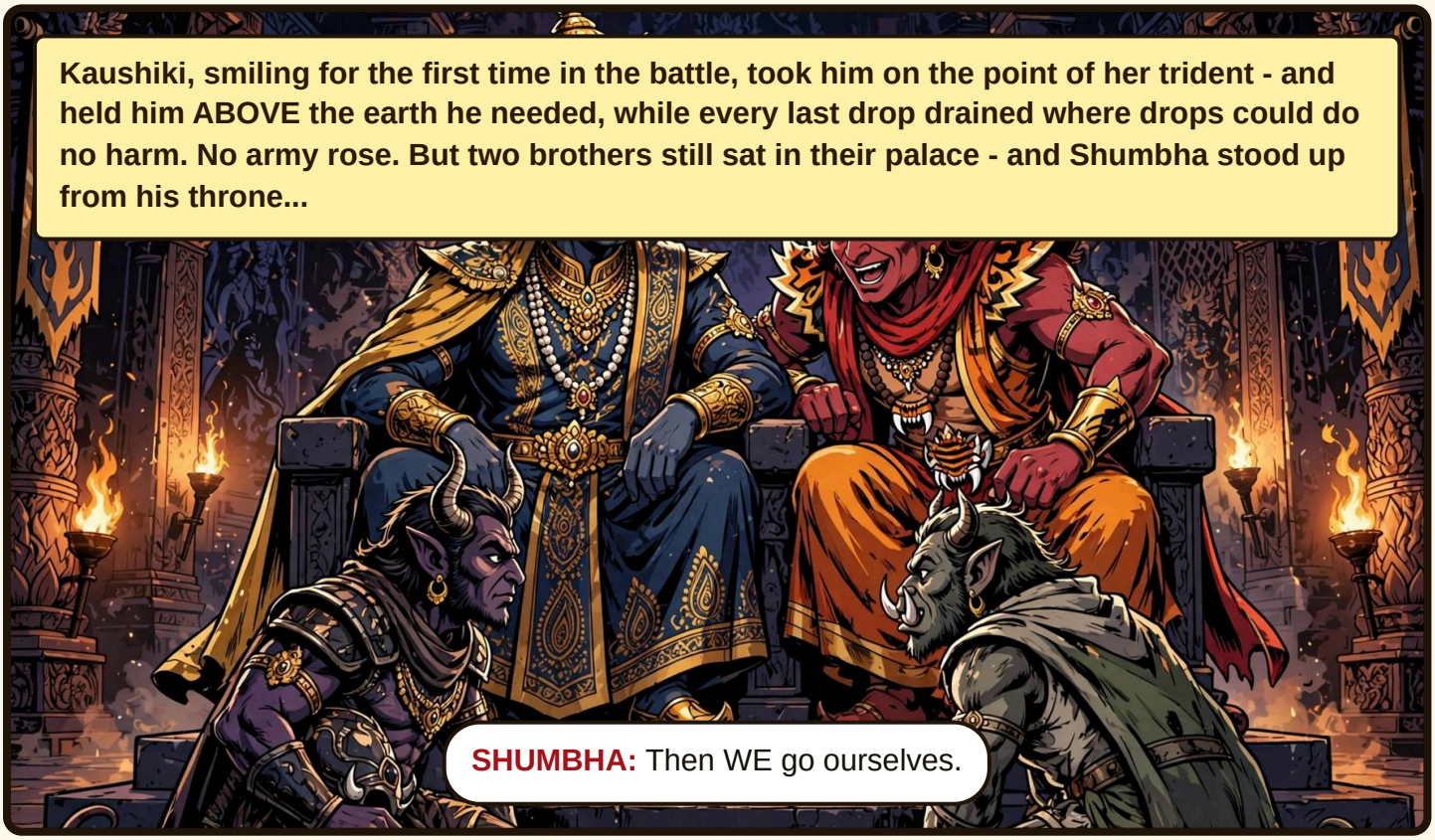


NOT ONE DROP REACHED THE EARTH

NOT ONE DROP REACHED THE EARTH



Strike - catch. Strike - catch. The Matrikas learned the new rhythm in moments, passing the falling drops from blade to cup to tongue the way villagers pass buckets to a fire, hand over hand. And the field, which had been filling, began - for the first time - to EMPTY. Raktabeej's laughter went first. Then his certainty.



What this story leaves with us: Some problems are Raktabeej problems - every angry answer makes two more. The goddesses did not win by hitting harder. They won by pausing, mid-battle, to ask what was feeding the enemy - and refusing to feed it.

Raktabeej: the trouble that feeds on the fighting

Every family knows a Raktabeej. The argument where each sharp reply produces two more. The bad habit where every guilty, angry attack on it leaves it stronger by evening. The worry that multiplies precisely because we keep striking at it in the dark.

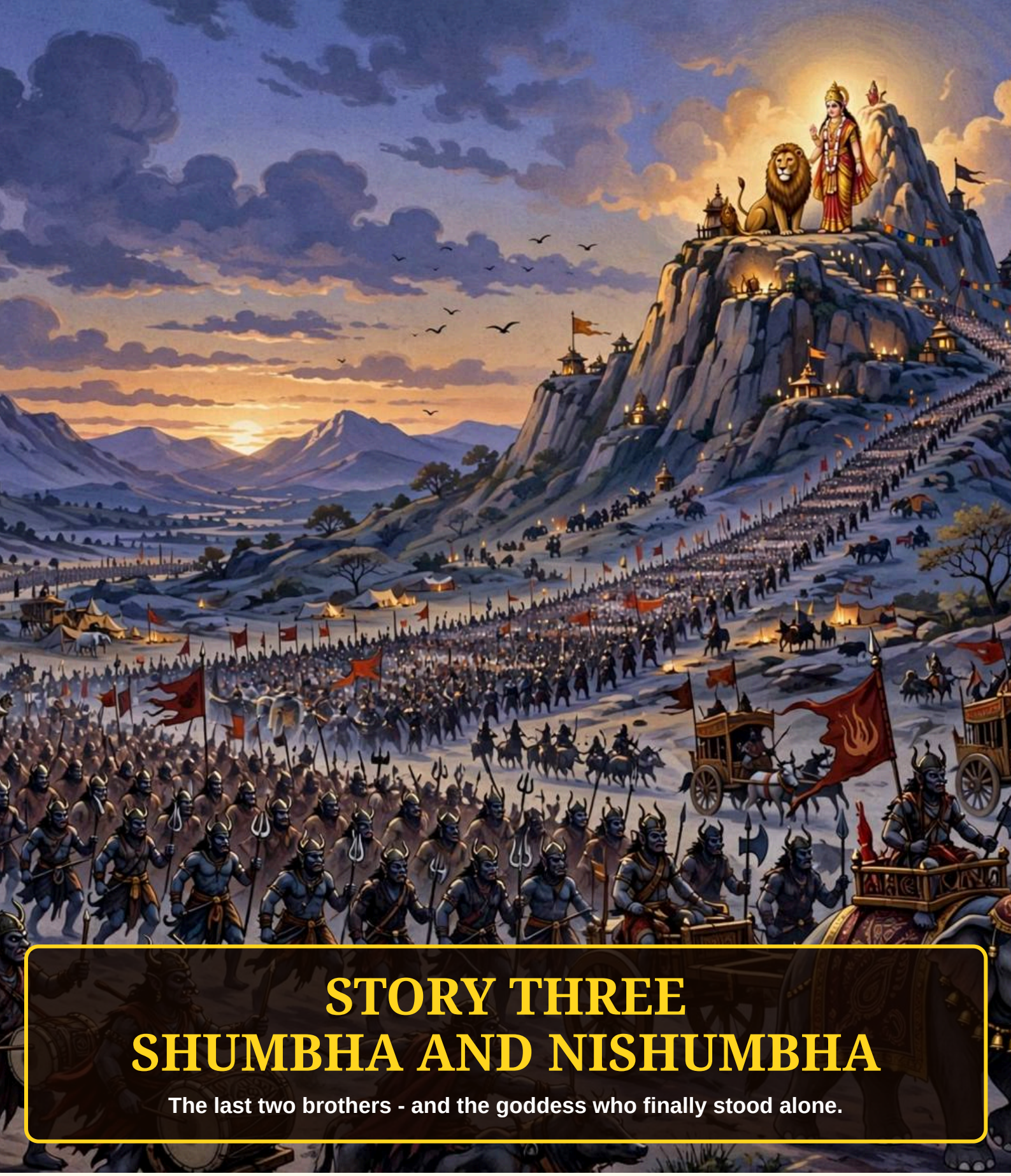
The goddesses do something rare in battle stories: they stop, mid-war, and ask a better question. Not 'how do we hit harder?' but 'what is feeding him?' The answer - the blood must touch earth - turns the whole fight. Kali's task is not destruction. It is *containment*: catch the drop before it lands. Do not let this angry word become tomorrow's new grievance.

There is a discipline hidden in this wildest of panels: pause between the strike and the consequence. In a quarrel, that pause is the breath before answering. In a habit, it is the moment between urge and act. The story suggests the pause is not weakness or delay. The pause is where the battle is actually won.

Source: Devi Mahatmyam (Durga Saptashati), Uttama Charita, Chapters 5 to 8 of 13 - the Goddess's encounter with the messengers (ch.5), Dhumralochana (ch.6), Chanda-Munda and the naming of Chamunda (ch.7), and Raktabeej (ch.8).

PAUSE AND TALK

Think of one recurring argument or worry between you. Where exactly is its 'drop touching the earth' moment - and what would catching it, together, actually look like this week?



STORY THREE
SHUMBHA AND NISHUMBHA

The last two brothers - and the goddess who finally stood alone.

PREVIOUSLY... Two new brothers, Shumbha and Nishumbha, sent armies to fetch a goddess as if she were treasure. Kali was born from the frown of Kaushiki and named Chamunda; the Divine Mothers descended; and Raktabeej - whose every drop of blood became another demon - fell only when Kali caught every drop before it touched the earth. Now no general is left to send. The brothers must come themselves...

STORY THREE - THE BROTHERS COME THEMSELVES

Understand the brothers before you judge them. By penance and by arms they had taken heaven itself. Nishumbha, the younger, loved glory the way a flame loves oil. Shumbha, the elder, loved OWNERSHIP - the world filed neatly as his property. What neither could do was hear the word NO as information instead of insult. So now they stopped sending others. The whole remaining might of the demon world poured out behind them in person.



On the mountain, the Goddess waited, unhurried, her lion asleep in the sun like a house-cat. She woke him with one hand as the ground began to tremble.



DURGA: Come. They have brought the whole story to us at last. Let us finish it properly.

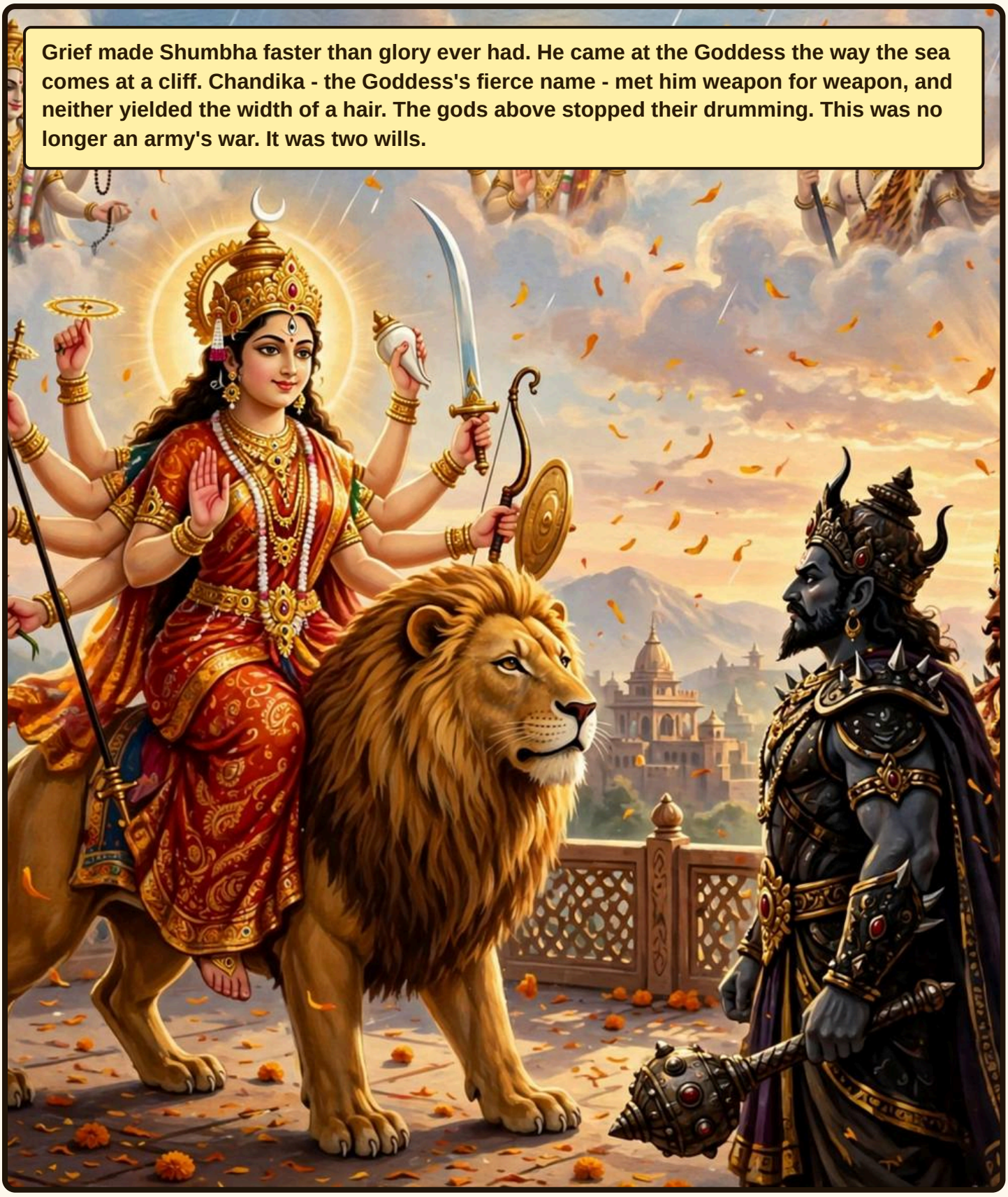
The Matrikas blazed at the front, each a small sun. Kali ranged where she was needed most. Then Nishumbha came at the Goddess in his chariot like a comet. His arrows broke on her armour. His finest spear she CAUGHT - caught, listener, in one hand, as you might catch a thrown fruit - and, smiling, struck him down with his own weapon returned by hers.



From Nishumbha's fallen body, a last warrior-spirit rose crying "Stay!" - loyalty outliving its own body - and the Goddess stilled that too, gently and completely. Then came the sound the whole war had been travelling toward. It was not a war-cry. It was Shumbha - screaming his brother's name across the field. He did not run. Credit him with this much: he CHARGED.



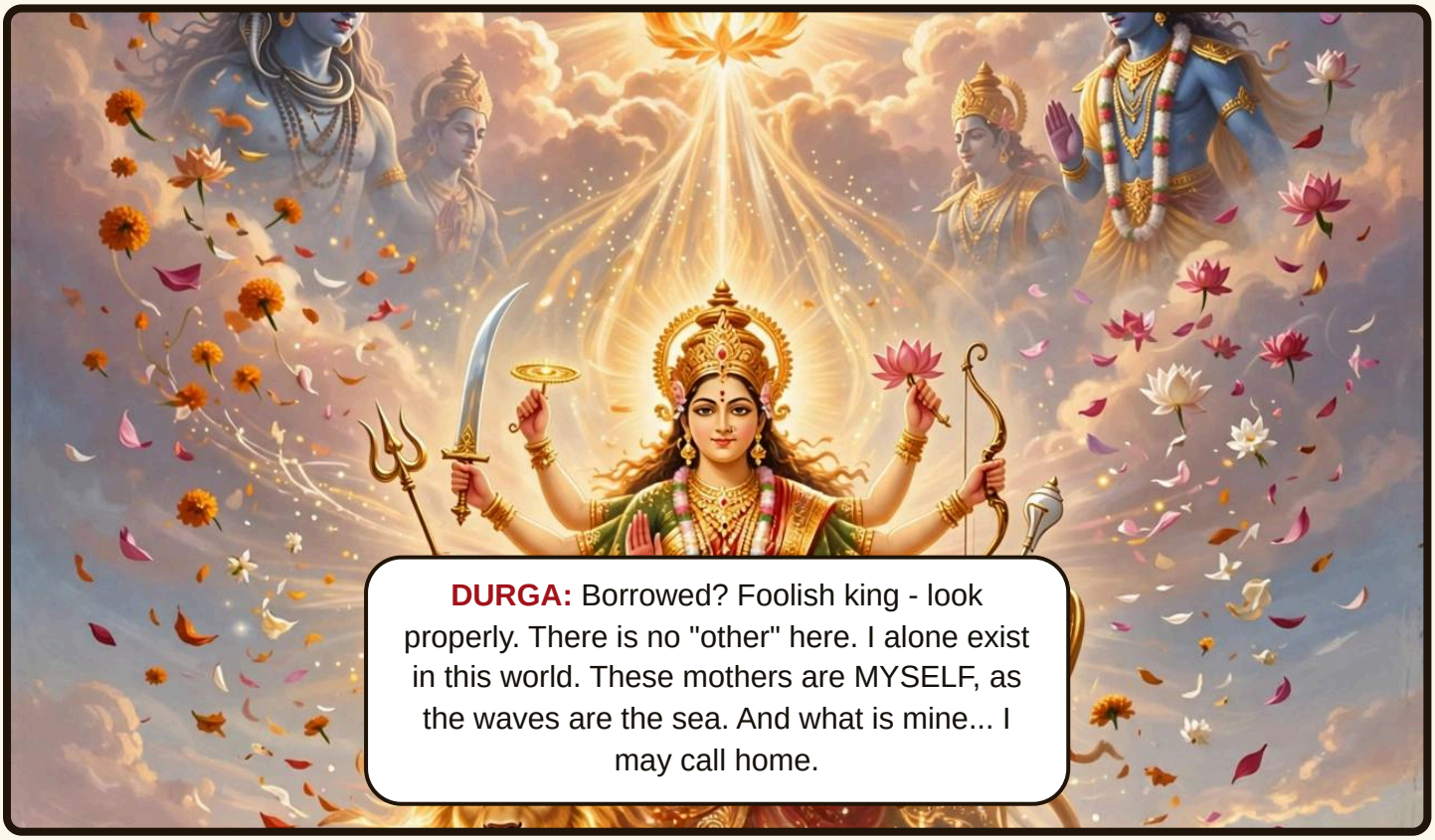
TWO WILLS



And it was Shumbha himself who spoke the line that ends the war - though he meant it as an insult, and it became the Goddess's invitation. Breathless, he looked at the ring of shining mothers around her, and sneered the most human sentence any demon speaks in this whole book...

"BORROWED STRENGTH!"





Feel the trap in that taunt - it is one we set for ourselves. How often do we dismiss what saves us - help, love, community, grace - as "borrowed", as if standing alone were the only honest way to stand? The Goddess did not argue. She smiled... and she called them home.

One by one, in full view of both armies, the Matrikas walked into her light and were gone - Brahmi, Maheshwari, Kaumari, Vaishnavi, Varahi, Indrani, and terrible Chamunda last of all - the way rivers enter the sea without ceasing to be water. Where an army of goddesses had stood, now ONE woman stood, alone on the field exactly as Shumbha had demanded - more radiant than all of them together. He had not reduced her. He had CONCENTRATED her.



ALONE - AND ENTIRE

He had asked, with his last cleverness, to face the Goddess undivided. His wish, like Brahma's boons, was granted precisely as spoken.

THE FINAL DUEL

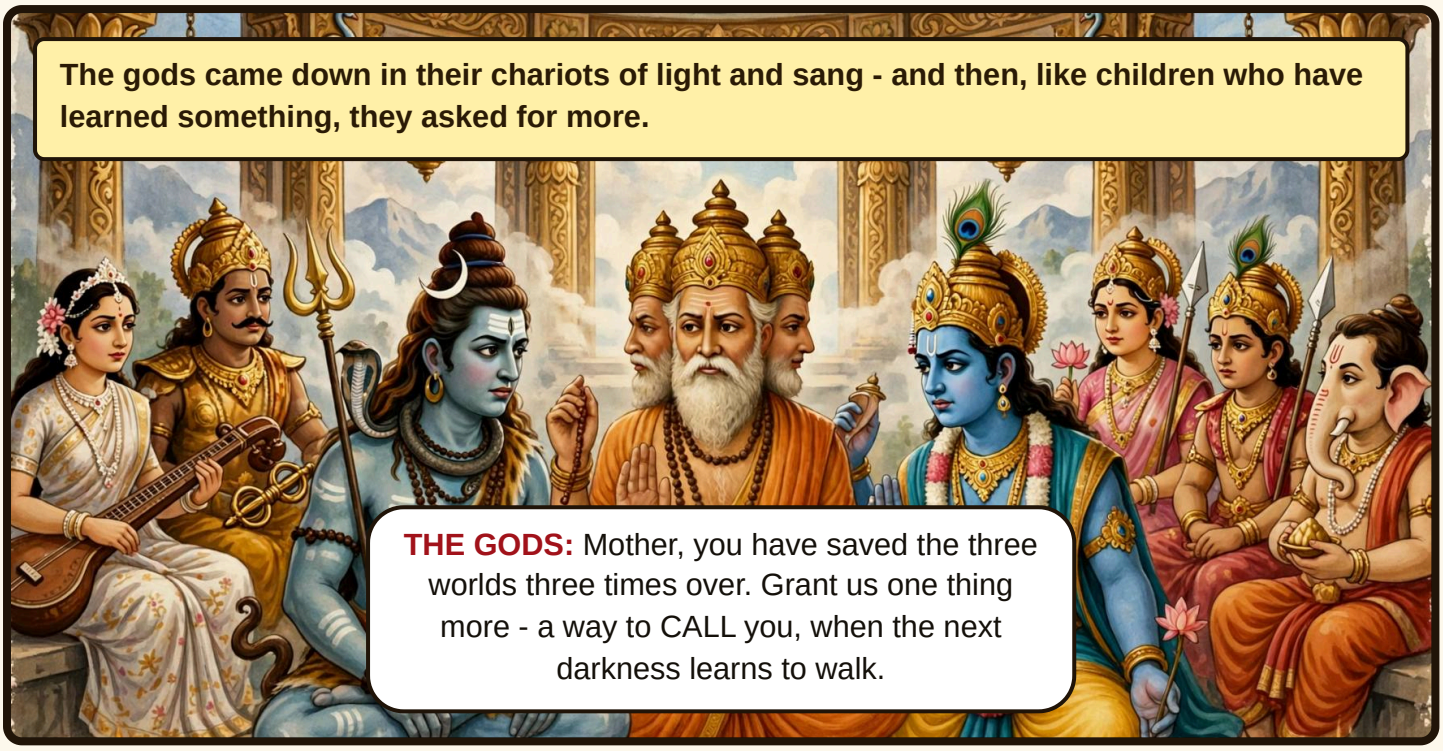
No armies interfere now. The field belongs to two figures and the dust. He fought - let it be said plainly - magnificently. A hundred arrows she split in the air. Again and again he closed with her, and again and again she turned him, unhurried - until at last she LIFTED him, armour, crown and all, whirled him in a great circle above her head as a potter whirls a wheel, and dashed him down upon the earth he had claimed to own.

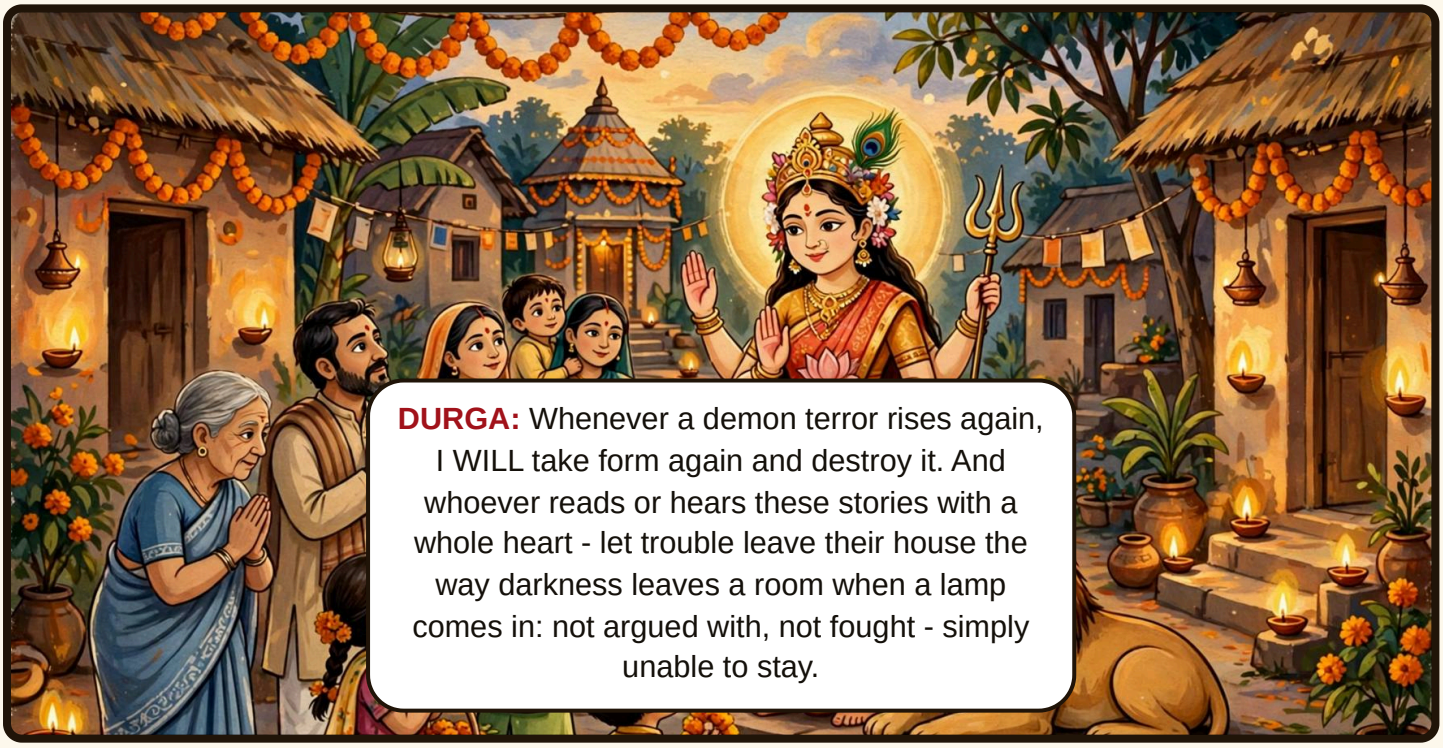


Even then he rose. Even then - crown rolling in the dust - Shumbha came at her with his fists, because there was nothing left in him to surrender with. The Goddess did not prolong it. Her trident - Shiva's own, given on the first morning of the first story - ended the last demon king, swift as mercy disguised as lightning. Then the sky cleared: rivers ran clean, fires burned steady, the sun stood out like a lamp newly trimmed, and the gods rained flowers and sang.



THE PROMISE SHE LEFT BEHIND





She named, in the old hymn, form after form she would yet come in - the Goddess of the Vindhya mountains, the bee-dark Goddess, the Mother who will come when the world is at its driest and most afraid. **Each name is a story for another evening.** Then she withdrew, as light withdraws at evening without going anywhere.

What this story leaves with us: Durga's strength was never borrowed - it was shared, which is a different thing entirely. And standing "alone", when the moment truly comes, turns out to mean standing as everything we have ever loved, at once.

Shumbha and Nishumbha: pride that wanted to own the Goddess

Mahishasura wanted a kingdom. These brothers wanted something more modern, and more dangerous: they wanted to *own* beauty itself. Kaushiki on her mountain was, to them, a jewel missing from a treasury. Their messengers do not threaten at first - they offer wealth, honour, a throne. The whole cycle is about what happens when 'no' is treated not as an answer, but as a negotiation that has not yet offered enough.

Then comes the taunt every reader remembers - 'borrowed strength!' It lands because it touches something true in all of us: the suspicion that help received is strength disqualified, that standing alone is the only honest way to stand. The Goddess's answer reframes it completely. The mothers are not her crutches; they are her expressions. What is gathered honestly - love, family, community, grace - is not borrowed. It is what a self is made of.

Alone on that field, she is not diminished. She is concentrated. That, perhaps, is the volume's last word on strength: not needing no one, but knowing exactly who you are when everyone who made you stands, gathered, inside you.

Source: Devi Mahatmyam (Durga Saptashati), Uttama Charita, Chapters 5 to 13 of 13 - the Shumbha-Nishumbha cycle: the embassy and Dhumralochana (ch.5-6), Chanda-Munda (ch.7), Raktabeej (ch.8), the slaying of Nishumbha (ch.9) and of Shumbha (ch.10), the gods' hymn (ch.11), the Goddess's boons and promise (ch.12), and the fruits of hearing the tale (ch.13). Story Two of this book retells ch.5-8 of the same cycle.

PAUSE AND TALK

Whose strength is gathered inside each of you - parents, teachers, each other - that you once might have called 'borrowed'? What changes when you call it 'mine, because it made me' instead?

For nine nights each autumn, families keep this victory the way you keep a fire in cold weather: by tending it together. In Gujarat, garba dances circle all night around a lamp for the Mother. In Bengal, Durga arrives in clay splendour for Durga Puja. In Mysuru, whose very name carries Mahishasura's, the palace blazes with light. And on the tenth day - Vijayadashami - the message is spoken aloud once more, so children hear it before the year turns: goodness, when it finally stands up, WINS.



Three demons, three lessons

- **Mahishasura** - the blind spot of pride: what we decide is "too small to matter" becomes the door our downfall uses.
- **Raktabeej** - multiplication: some troubles feed on our very way of fighting them. Change the fight, do not just enlarge it.
- **Shumbha** - wholeness: the strength we share is not borrowed. Gathered honestly, it is what we are made of.

Say the names slowly - the stories forgive every accent

Durga (DUR-gaa), Shakti (SHUK-ti), Mahishasura (ma-hi-SHAA-su-ra), Kaushiki (kau-SHI-ki), Kali / Chamunda (KAA-lee / chaa-MUN-daa), Matrikas (MAA-tri-kaas), Raktabeej (RUK-ta-beej), Shumbha & Nishumbha (SHUM-bha, ni-SHUM-bha), Navratri (nav-RAA-tri), Vijayadashami (vi-ja-ya-da-SHA-mi).

These tales come from the **Devi Mahatmyam** (Durga Saptashati) in the ancient Markandeya Purana - retold here faithfully, in pictures and speech, for reading aloud. Waiting in the next volumes: **Shiva and Parvati**, **Vishnu's avatars**, and **Narad**, the travelling sage whose news starts a hundred stories.

JAI MATA DI - VICTORY TO THE MOTHER

THE END